

Advancing Equity in Ski Racing

Grant Proposal for a Statewide Subsidized Mountain Access Program
for Young Athletes



December 15, 2025
Submitted by Louise Filkorn
On Behalf of Vermont Alpine Racing Association

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12.15.2025

Lynn Boynton
Grant Manager
1 Killington Rd
Killington, VT 05751

Dear Ms. Boynton,

Please consider this letter as part of the formal application for a Killington World Cup Foundation grant on behalf of the Vermont Alpine Racing Association, or VARA. VARA is a nonprofit organization with a mission to develop programs that are both athletic and educational, helping skiers reach world-class status and become lifelong participants. As the primary governing body of alpine racing in Vermont, VARA is committed to fostering a diverse and inclusive community around ski racing through programs and initiatives.

The contents of this application focus on the proposition of a Racer Pass that would provide access to all ski areas across Vermont for racers aged 6 - 16. This program would be implemented through a phase based process eventually providing access to all Vermont ski racers under the age of 16. The goal of the Racer Pass is to limit one of the costly aspects of ski racing, opening up opportunities for athletes from all socio-economic and ethnic backgrounds. We are seeking \$1,500,000 over a four year period to compensate ski areas for their participation in this project.

Currently there are options available to lower costs such as used equipment and participating in smaller club teams, yet this is not nearly enough to make ski racing an affordable option for families with young athletes. In the following proposal you will find a clear plan for implementation, goals and objectives, and a clear explanation of where the funding will be going and how it will be allocated. This program will support youth and development programs, and increase participation in winter sports programs throughout the Northeast as stated in the goals of your organization.

We greatly appreciate your consideration and if you have any questions or thoughts about the program please do not hesitate to reach out to the email provided above.

Best Regards,

Louise Filkorn on Behalf of VARA

Statement of the Problem

Accessibility is not a term generally associated with alpine ski racing. From early mornings, extensive travel, coaching, equipment, event fees, and countless unforeseen costs, ski racing has become associated with higher income individuals. Some changes to the sport programming have eased the burden for participants: academies (ski racing specific boarding schools) offer scholarships, smaller clubs supplement fees with fundraising, and second hand equipment is made available through ski swaps and other means. Yet the costs of participating in the sport are still extremely high and have become a challenge for even well off-families. Additionally, socio-economic and racial diversity is a frequent topic of discussion within ski racing, especially in Vermont where the population is around 90% white. The lack of diversity is a critical aspect that ties in heavily with the exorbitant costs and needs to be addressed. Improving access to participation will enhance competition for racers' development, and yield a broader pipeline of ski enthusiasts for the benefit of the ski areas.

Financial Burden of Alpine Ski Racing

Time on snow, access to training opportunities, and sufficient coaching are the key to success in the ski racing world. Technical and foundational skills need time to develop and education is still a priority, creating a draw for athletes to go to academies where athletic success is balanced with academic achievement, but this comes with extremely high costs. According to Mark Wolcott with Ski Racing Media, a family in the top 10% of American wage earners making \$200,000 per year, \$135,000 after tax deductions, would be spending 46% of their yearly net income to send an athlete to a top ski academy with the price tag of just over \$62,000 per year. Additionally, a recent study done by U.S. Ski & Snowboard that surveyed clubs across the country found that "the total gross cost for a junior ski racing career up through the high school level could total more than half a million dollars for those in the elite programs. And there are many in private scenarios spending far more"(Porino). This is far out of reach for many potential athletes pushing them away from the sport as a whole or leading them to join small clubs and weekend programs.

Estimated Overall Cost for Athletes aged 6-16 not Attending Academy Program:

- **Team Fees:**
 - \$1600 to \$7000 per season (depends on club)
- **Seasons Passes:**
 - \$200 to \$1,500 per season (depends on mountain)
- **USCSA Licence:**
 - \$200-300 (required for all athletes, other licences required once 16 years old)
- **Equipment:**
 - \$500 - \$8,000 (average range, could be more or less)
- **Race Fees and Lift Tickets, per event:**
 - \$24 at the very beginner level up to \$200 at the U16 level
 - discounted racer tickets are often about \$70 per day (races often 2 day events)
- **Travel Fees, per event:**

- 3-4 nights in a hotel ≈ \$400
- Gas for travel \$60 - \$100 (can be from 10 min drive to 6 hours)

In total, on the low end costs are estimated at around \$3,000 and on the high end \$20,000 per season per athlete. The price point has a wide range due to the amount of events an athlete may participate in per season. This estimate does not include camps, potential medical needs, summer travel, or academy prices. With this price tag, ski racing is undeniably an elitist sport and something needs to change so athletes with potential or interest are not slipping through the cracks due to financial barriers.

For clubs, the ability to reduce costs on access allows coaches to plan for a wider variety of training options, use different types of terrain, and keep athletes for a longer period of time who otherwise would leave the sport due to finances. For ski resorts, expanding youth participation helps them build long-term loyalty to their resort through early brand loyalty and increased race attendance and promotes family return as recreational skiers. The most important benefit of increasing access for youth is that it increases the pipeline of youth entering the sport; therefore it creates an expanded and more competitive, integrated and sustainable ski racing eco-system throughout Vermont. By lessening barriers to mountain access for youth, the foundation for equitable access and the future growth of alpine ski racing will be greatly enhanced.

Diversity and Inclusion of Alpine Ski Racing

Skiing's introduction to the United States by Scandinavian immigrants in the late 19th century, initially as a means for transportation in rural mountain areas, transformed into a recreational sport enjoyed almost exclusively by affluent Americans who had previously experienced European ski culture on their vacations abroad. Today, with countless resorts across the country there is more accessibility for all races, yet it is still a predominantly white sport. Marketing driven by the influence of European culture within the sport creates intentional racialization of skiing imagery, spaces, and resorts pushing people of color away. According to research done by Snowsports Industries America, “non-White skiers accounted for about one third (31.3%) of all skiers in the 2019-2020 season. Of that 31.3%, only 6.9% were Black” (Rivas-Triana).

Ski Participants by Ethnicity

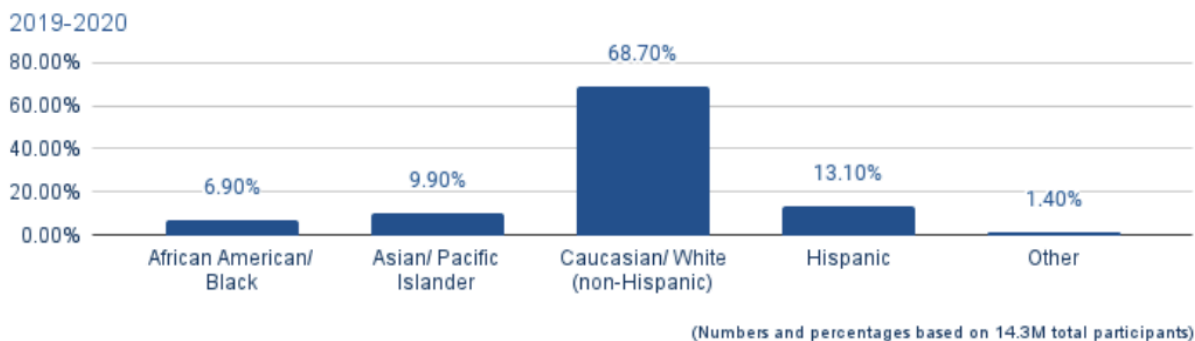


Figure 1: Graph by Ashley Rivas-Triana. Data source: SIA 2019-2020 Participation Survey

These statistics carry over into ski racing with a severe lack of diversity at both youth and professional levels. On the current U.S Ski team there is not a single athlete of color, all are white and majority come from a background of wealth or generational skiing. The disparities within the professional realm start from youth as identified by U.S. Ski and Snowboard as they released a Diversity and Inclusion Strategic Plan in 2017. “U.S. Ski & Snowboard has been seeking athletes in underserved demographics to expand the pool of elite athletes”(Shaw). It is believed that youth initiatives prioritizing underserved demographics will expand the pool of elite athletes and will be the key to creating a more inclusive sports environment.

Statement of Request

On behalf of VARA, Vermont Alpine Racing Association, we are requesting a grant of \$1,500,000 over a four year period from the Killington World Cup Foundation to establish a program providing free mountain access to youth alpine ski racers from the ages of 6 to 16. Our goal is to create a Racer Pass to bridge the accessibility gap for athletes from all backgrounds, both ethnic and economic by giving all interested the opportunity to engage with ski racing at a lower cost. It aims to support youth and development and increase participation in alpine ski racing throughout Vermont.

The Racer Pass would provide athletes with the opportunity to ski at all mountains in Vermont with the purchase of their home mountain pass and an additional fee of \$100. The implementation of this program would negate one of the larger costs that racers face as they travel to different mountains for races by cutting out race day pass fees. Additionally it will encourage athletes to experience different terrain by exploring Vermont and benefiting their skiing as a whole.

While this program is designed to significantly reduce financial barriers, it is intentionally structured to maintain shared responsibility between participating families, VARA, and partner ski areas. The required \$100 athlete contribution serves as an important mechanism to promote participant buy-in, program sustainability, and responsible use of the Racer Pass. Rather than functioning as a fully subsidized benefit, this contribution ensures that families remain active stakeholders in their athlete’s participation while still experiencing a substantial reduction in overall costs. Maintaining a modest participant fee also helps reinforce the value of the program and discourage misuse, ensuring that the Racer Pass is utilized as intended for training and competition purposes.

Grant funding from the Killington World Cup Foundation will therefore subsidize access, not replace personal responsibility, by covering the majority of costs associated with raceday and intermountain lift access. This shared cost model allows limited grant dollars to reach a greater number of athletes over time while preserving the financial viability of participating ski areas.

Description of Proposed Work

This project will take significant time and funding to fully implement due to the number of athletes currently participating in the sport and high costs of support. It will follow a phase-based implementation that begins with supporting 500 athletes within the bottom financial bracket with a family income of \$50,000 or less annually. This will prioritize the athletes that need the most support while testing the functionality of this program. Once analysis has been done on the effectiveness of achieving the following defined objectives, the program will become accessible for athletes of all income levels.

Objectives

- Reduce annual race day costs by at least 30% for participating Vermont alpine ski racers ages 6–16 during the first season of the Racer Pass program.
- Provide statewide mountain access to 500 youth athletes across Vermont clubs within the first year of program implementation.
- Increase youth participation in Vermont alpine ski racing by 15% over four seasons by lowering financial barriers to entry and competition.
- Improve athlete development opportunities by ensuring participating athletes ski and train at multiple Vermont mountains (minimum of 4 per season), expanding terrain exposure and skill growth.
- Expand access for underserved and underrepresented populations by allocating at least 25% of Racer Passes to athletes from communities traditionally underrepresented in alpine ski racing within four years.

Timeline

Since the 2025-2026 season has already begun and most athletes have bought their seasons passes and paid for VARA registration, the implementation of this project will begin for the 2026-2027 season.

Phase Based Implementation of Racer Pass			
Phase	Year/Season	# of Participating Athletes	Goal
1	2026 - 2027	500	Participating athletes ski at 4+ mountains using the pass
2	2027 - 2028	750	Reduce race day cost by 30% for participating athletes
3	2028 - 2029	1,000	Improve ethnic diversity by 10%

Phase Based Implementation of Racer Pass			
4	2029 - 2030	All Vermont Youth Alpine Racers aged 6 to 16 (≈ 1,500)	Increased participation by 15% within ski racing in VT

Figure 2: Phase Based Implementation of Racer Pass

Phase 1

The primary goal of Racer Pass is to lower the overall cost of ski racing, so Phase 1 will focus primarily on low income athletes. Beginning with 500 athletes who have a family income of \$50,000 annually will ensure that the athletes who need it the most are the first to be supported. To ensure that athletes qualify for this support, when signing up for VARA in the beginning of the season, athletes will be encouraged to fill out a financial need assessment survey as part of registration, similar to a FAFSA. This form will ask questions regarding demographics and family income. Results from this form will determine eligibility for the program and provide valuable data to measure the success in following years. Once athletes are verified and qualify, the 500 from diverse ethnic and socioeconomic backgrounds will be provided with the “all access pass” to mountains in Vermont.

Phase 2 and Phase 3

The following 2 seasons, Phase 2 and 3 will primarily focus on expanding the reach of Racer Pass making it accessible to 250 more athletes each year. By thoughtfully expanding the program, access will expand to serve those athletes who may not need as much financial assistance. This will ensure that accessibility is shared since it has been statistically proven that even the top 10% of families can struggle to pay the high costs of ski racing.

Phase 4

The final stage of this program will ensure access to all athletes aged 6 - 16 participating in ski racing in Vermont. The initial form that will be included in VARA registration will still be in effect to receive data regarding athlete participation, yet will not be used to select participants. At this point mountains will be familiar with the program and it will be instituted for all subsequent seasons. By the end of this process, athletes will have lower costs as a whole, more access to terrain, and a more diverse team dynamic.

Measurement of Success

To ensure that progress is being made towards lowering costs and increasing diversity, success will be measured using four primary methods. These methods will mainly focus on statistical analysis of the demographics of ski racing within Vermont and feedback from participants

including ski areas, athletes, and clubs. This data will be analyzed internally by VARA to measure the success of the program.

1. The initial form when registering for VARA:

Since all athletes are required to register with VARA when racing at the U8 to U16 level, (ages 6 to 16) the initial registration form will provide valuable information for measuring the progress of the program. VARA already has access to data regarding how many athletes are participating at each level of the sport and the additional demographic and financial information will be critical to analyze the progress regarding both ethnic and socioeconomic diversity.

2. Feedback Forms from Participating Athletes:

At the end of the season, or beginning of the following season, athletes who participated in the program will be asked a short series of questions regarding their experience. This will give them the opportunity to express their thoughts on the program, how it improved their experience, performance, and anything they think needs improvement. This again will be looked over internally and taken into consideration as the following season approaches and adjustments to the program are considered. This feedback will be critical as the athlete is the number one priority.

3. Feedback Forms from Clubs:

In the primary months of each season, coaches from all clubs in Vermont will be asked a series of questions regarding their athletes. These will include, but are not limited to questions regarding the diversity of their team, cost of being on the team, whether or not they took advantage of the pass and took the team to a different mountain for training, and any other feedback they may have. This will enable VARA to get a sense of which clubs are utilizing the pass, how it is impacting their programs and whether availability of existing resources influence participation.

4. Feedback Forms from Mountains/Ski Areas:

Following each season a representative from each ski area will be asked to share data regarding the effects of the program on their business. These questions include how many times a racer pass was used at the mountain, if there was a significant impact on yearly gross sales, and other feedback they may have.

Description of Available Facilities

There are a total of 25 ski areas in the state of Vermont and 24 ski clubs. Of all the ski areas Vail Resorts owns 3, Alterra owns 2, Pacific Resorts Group owns 1, and 19 are independent. Vermont is unique in that the majority of ski areas are independently owned and operated, some are even non-profit organizations, but this does not mean that all passes are affordable. To ensure the effectiveness of the Racer Pass, all 25 resorts would need to agree to the terms and conditions. For small independent ski areas the loss of revenue could be significant as many rely on hosting races as a significant part of their revenue. Yet on the other hand, they are more in touch



with the local community and would likely be supportive of youth development. The large corporations, Vail, Alterra, and Pacific Resorts Group, may be less inclined to participate in this program. There is a significant disconnect between the decision makers at these large corporations and the communities they are serving. Since 24/25 ski areas have a ski club ideally there will be a baseline understanding of the needs surrounding athletes. Getting all ski areas on board by supplying sufficient financial compensation will be a crucial aspect to the success of the program.

Participating Resorts:

- **Alterra:** Stratton Mountain Resort and Sugarbush
- **Pacific Group Resorts:** Jay Peak
- **Vail Resorts:** Mount Snow, Okemo, and Stowe Mountain Resort
- **Non-Profit:** Brattleboro Ski Hill, Cochran's Ski Area, Hard'ack, Lyndon Outing Club, and Northeast Slopes
- **Independent:** Ascutney Outdoors, Bellows Falls, Bolton Valley, Bromley Mountain, Burke Mountain, Harrington Hill, Killington, Mad River Glen, Magic Mountain, Middlebury Snow Bowl, Pico, Ski Quechee, Smugglers' Notch, Suicide Six

Qualifications of Personnel

Julie Woodworth, VARA Executive Director

The Vermont Alpine Racing Association (VARA) is a 501(c)(7) nonprofit focused on supporting ski racing in the state. Their leadership consists of a board of 20 individuals who establish goals and areas of improvement while implementing national protocols with the priority of Vermont youth ski racing development. As the executive director, Julie Woodworth provides valuable insight on the inner workings of VARA and the ski racing community as a whole. As a former elite ski racer, she is passionate about opening up the world she cares so much about to everyone by providing resources so all athletes can participate. Her role in this project would be the primary liaison between the VARA board and the mountains participating in this project. Her expertise will be valuable when it comes to convincing ski areas that this is an important project to participate in.

Bobby Farrell, Cochran's Ski Club Program Director

Coming from a family of ski racers, Bobby Farrell is passionate about making ski racing affordable and accessible. As the program director at Cochran's Ski Club, a small low budget team that prides itself on accessibility and inclusion, he has been working in the realm of lowering alpine racing costs for the club and individuals. In 2012 he started a program with VARA that sent \$1,000 to clubs in support of U12 and under athletes. His success in creating this program will be valuable when it comes to implementation and public outreach.

Budget

This project requests a grant for \$1,500,000 over a four year period. The table below offers a breakdown of each phase and its required funding.

Funds Required per Phase/Season				
Phase	Year/Season	Finances Received from Athletes	Estimated Total Cost	Grant Money Needed (Total Cost - Athlete Funds)
1	2026 - 2027	\$50,000	\$250,000	\$200,000
2	2027 - 2028	\$75,000	\$375,000	\$300,000
3	2028 - 2029	\$100,000	\$500,000	\$400,000
4	2029 - 2030	\$150,000	\$750,000	\$600,000
Totals:	4 years	\$375,000	\$1,875,000	\$1,500,000

Figure 3: Cost breakdown of Racer Pass Program

The funds from this grant will go directly to participating resorts to compensate for revenue loss related to the program. At the end of each season, ski areas will report how many times the racer pass was used at their mountain. Once all the information is present, the available funds will be dispersed to each ski area based on how many times athletes used the facilities and cost of a day pass at said mountain. This will ensure that for small mountains that rely on the revenue from pass sales, they will be compensated enough to keep facilities running and large mountains will see a negligible decrease in revenue.

Additional funding could be brought to the table through fundraising and the option to donate when signing up for the program. This way, families with higher income can support those who are struggling to continue the sport.

The ski areas and local businesses may also see this program as an opportunity to show support for community investment and incorporate it into their marketing plans.

Summary

In conclusion, the Racer Pass program would benefit not only athletes in Vermont, but the racing community as a whole. By lowering the cost of raceday and mountain access a wide range of athletes would be encouraged to participate and have the opportunity to develop their ski racing abilities. This will be beneficial for not only VARA and the Vermont skiing community, but will additionally foster a more diverse group of athletes that have the potential to compete at higher levels.

The Racer Pass program not only affects Vermont athletes, it also has the potential to create a scalable model for equitable access to winter sports across the United States. Vermont has always been viewed as a leader in developing youth alpine racer development and has the unique opportunity to show how intentional funding and policy decisions reduce barriers for all skiers and expands the overall vitality of the sport. The statewide nature of ski area lift accessibility gives the Racer Pass program a structural framework on which other states, regions, and governing bodies may adapt their own ski communities.

The Racer Pass is changing how youth sports access is viewed—changing access to facilities from being an individual burden to being a shared public resource. With assistance from independent and corporate ski areas and a determined state governing body, Vermont can, and will, create a model of inclusive growth in winter sports. Successful execution of this initiative will place Vermont on a national level as an example of how equitable investments in youth allow for increased participation, improved athlete development, and ultimately, long-term sustainability of ski racing as a viable sport.

The addition of this program to the Vermont skiing landscape will bring new ideas and new individuals with the potential to transform the ecosystem of skiing. By creating a more diverse space within ski racing, individuals will be inspired to try skiing though they may have felt that it was not for them, or they don't belong. These changes will carry through generations and inspire a new culture within the sport of skiing as a whole.

There is no competition when it comes to Racer Pass. It is a new idea that will benefit all communities and will have the support of all individuals interested in the improvement of equity and inclusion within sports. This has been done before with other sports like public access basketball hoops and soccer fields which have produced countless elite athletes. For example, Messi, a now world famous soccer player grew up in a home environment experiencing extreme poverty. His family faced significant financial hardship causing him to have medical issues due to lack of nutrition. His access to local soccer fields gave him the opportunity to pull not only himself but his family out of poverty and has contributed to be one of the most famous athletes of all time. Without this access to sports his potential could have gone undiscovered. This is true for all sports and the same ideas can be carried into the world of ski racing. There is countless untapped potential that could go left undiscovered if ski racing keeps the high price tag that many athletes are familiar with. It is critical that sports are made more accessible to all individuals and with ski racing, it can all start with Racer Pass.

Potential Barriers for Success

The ability to persuade all mountains in Vermont to participate in this program and give up potential revenue will be the biggest barrier for success when it comes to the Racer Pass. Since many are for profit, financial gain is their main priority, not the success and inclusion of young athletes. Although the process of engaging these ski areas will be difficult, there are many benefits that they will be receiving. If more athletes are participating in the sport, there will be more income from race fees and potential on mountain hotel stays. Additionally, the opportunity

to try out different ski areas for such a low cost will cause racers to fall in love with a mountain, and when they're too old for the program, they may purchase a seasons pass. In other words, it is free publicity for the resorts. Their parents or other family might come skiing, again increasing profit. Overall, it may seem like a big hit to the revenue of a mountain, but with the proposed grant funds and free publicity, the overall impact would be positive.

The Racer Pass program not only acknowledges potential barriers to implementation, but is deliberately designed for long-term sustainability. The phased approach to introducing Racer Passes will enable VARA to assess resort engagement, youth participation and the financial impact prior to statewide rollout of the Racer Pass initiative. Ski areas are anticipated to see a rise in youth participation rates, increased attendance at ski races and stronger customer loyalty as awareness grows about Racer Pass benefits; thus potentially reducing the amount of outside funding required over time.

While the Racer Pass program acknowledges potential barriers to implementation, VARA believes that as awareness increases about the benefits associated with purchasing a Racer Pass, more ski areas will experience an increase in youth participation rates; increased attendance at ski races; and stronger long-term customer loyalty. This may, in turn, create less reliance on outside cash subsidies over time.

Furthermore, VARA will collect data via athlete registration, athlete surveys and reports created by ski areas to develop a data/evidence base for continued funding for the Racer Pass Program through sponsorships, public-private partnerships and/or philanthropic dollars. The relatively small financial contribution from each athlete to purchase a Racer Pass also creates additional funding opportunities for VARA, which allows grant funds to be utilized more effectively across multiple seasons.

Appendices of Figures and Additional Information

Cover Image: Cochran's Holiday Slalom: Photo Credit Tucker Marshall

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Figure 1: Graphical representation of diversity within ski racing from the article *White as Snow: An Examination of Race within Skiing* by Ashley Rivas-Triana. Further information regarding frequency by ethnicity below.

Ski Participants by Ethnicity & Frequency

2019-2020

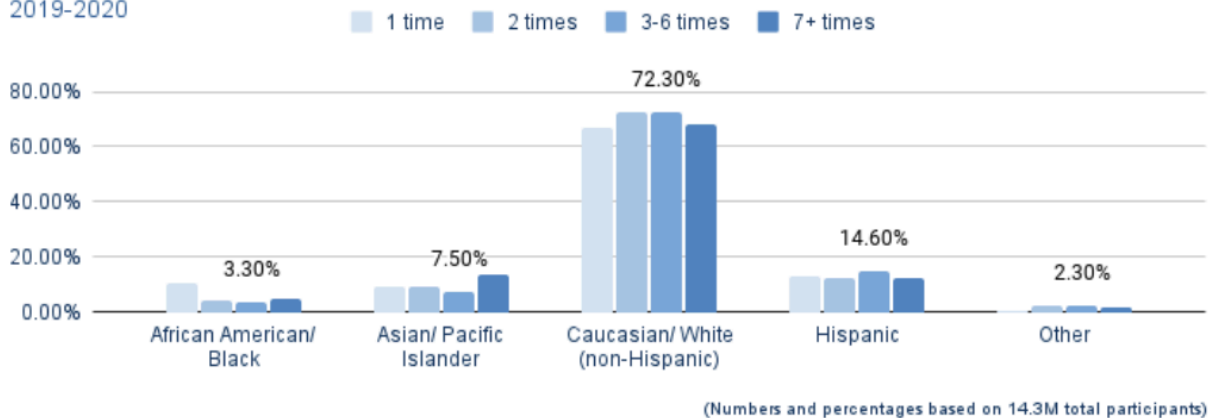


Image of Ski Areas in Vermont: This image has 30 resorts marked; the 5 that have not been accounted for are for personal use by friends and family only. These include Cosmic Hill, Pine Mountain, Hitching Post Farm, Pete's Hill / Gebbies' Farm, and Vermont Tech Ski Tow. Best Maps Ever. "Vermont Ski Areas & Resorts List." Best Maps Ever, bestmapsever.com/pages/vermont-ski-areas-resorts-list?srsId=AfmBOor_LPRNjQWQSIzGpSfWo5K9-QryKsRIhHK2zuaF1U8BRDx5mGXJ. Accessed 15 Dec. 2025.

Figure 2: Tabular representation of the Phase Based Implementation of Racer Pass highlighting number of athletes reached with the program and goals for each season.

Calculations for Number of Athletes:

Estimated average of 150 girls, and 150 boys per age group
 5 age groups, U8, U10, U12, U14, U16 (for ages 6 to 16)
 Estimated total 1,500 athletes in Vermont age 6 - 16

Figure 3: Cost breakdown of Racer Pass Program including income from athletes and overall funding needs based on the 4 phase implementation plan.

Calculations for Cost:

There are 25 participating ski areas
 Day pass costs \$5 - \$200 depending on the mountain
 Athletes would use the pass 1x biweekly for 20 weeks, 10 times total
 Average 500\$ per athlete needed

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